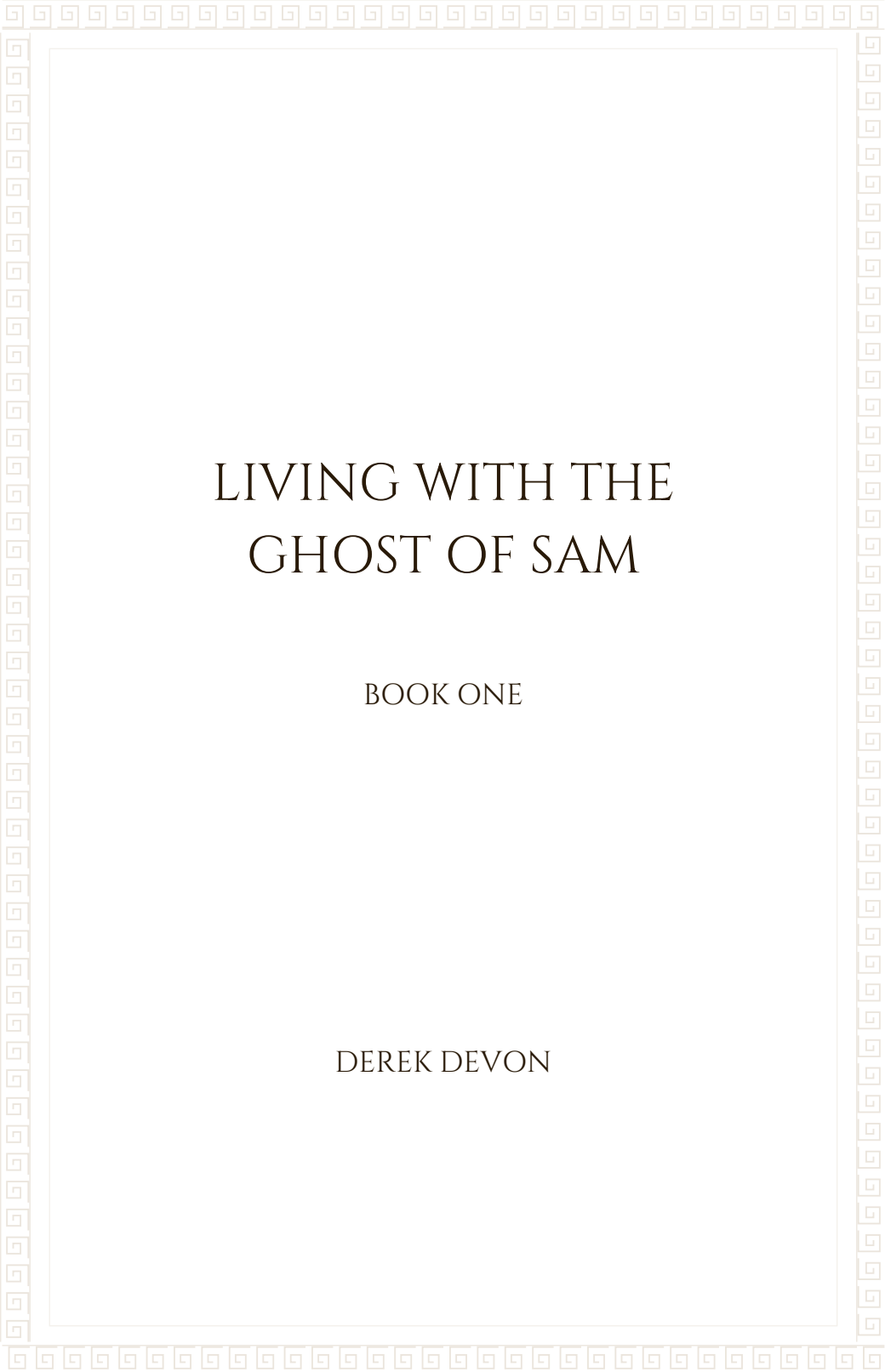




LIVING WITH THE GHOST OF SAM

BOOK ONE

DEREK DEVON

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For Sam Kinison
(1953–1992)

who proved that a scream could be a love language,
and that the loudest voice in the room
could carry the biggest heart.

The story is fiction.
The laughter it chases was real.

OH... OH... OHHHHH.

THE LIVING WITH THE GHOST OF SAM SERIES

Book One — Living With the Ghost of Sam

Book Two — Night Moves

Book Three — [Title]

Book Four — Last Laugh

Book Five — Digital Inheritance

Book Six — Missing

Book Seven — Command Performance

Book Eight — The Strange Emergence of Ms. Peel

Book Nine — [Title]

Book Ten — The Big Shoe, Parts One & Two

CHAPTER 1

THE MORNING EVERYTHING CHANGED

You never know when life's gonna hit you with the punchline...

The voice—if it was a voice—drifted somewhere between the stars and the atmosphere, too faint to be heard by the two astronauts floating in the cupola of the International Space Station. One of them pointed down at the blue curve of the Pacific coast, where San Francisco lay wrapped in its morning fog like a city that had hit snooze on itself. From up there, the bridges were silver threads. The traffic was a rumor. Everything looked peaceful.

Everything, from a sufficient distance, always does.

Down through the clouds, past the bridges, past the hills, past the eternally doomed search for parking and the ever-climbing price of sourdough, sat a row of tightly packed townhouses in the Marina District. And inside one of them, at exactly 5:45 a.m., an alarm clock was about to commit an act of cosmic timing.

BEEP-BEEP-BEEP.

The radio kicked in mid-broadcast, the DJ's voice cutting through the dark bedroom: "...and on this day in 1992, we lost comedy legend Sam Kinison..."

Derek Kinison's hand came down on the alarm hard enough to make it a warning to all future alarms. He sat up, disoriented, heart going for no reason he could name. In the dresser mirror across the room, his reflection caught him—and for a split second, it wasn't quite his. The eyes were wilder. The grin was wider. The face looking back belonged to a man who had once made entire theaters check their drink orders and their life choices simultaneously.

Derek blinked hard, and it was gone. Just a thirty-eight-year-old marketing executive with pillow creases on his cheek and a presentation at nine.

Beside him, his wife stirred. Nancy Hammond—she'd kept her name over his mother's objections, one of the many small battles she'd won with a smile—let out the little morning grunt she would deny making until her dying day.

Derek gave her a gentle elbow. "Hey, cute stuff. Time to move that awesome ass."

"Five minutes more, pleaseeeee." She rolled onto her stomach and pulled the covers over her head, a tactical retreat perfected over years of marriage.

Derek stared at the ceiling. "Did you hear thunder a few seconds ago?"

"Probably your stomach," came the muffled reply. "I told you those extra-hot Brassie wings would come back to haunt you."

Haunt. Funny choice of word. He filed it away and got up.



In the bathroom, Derek stood before the mirror in his perfectly pressed suit and practiced his presentation smile. It was a good smile. Focus-grouped, essentially. The problem was that this morning it kept slipping—the corners pulling wider than intended, the eyes going bright with something that had no business in a quarterly review.

"Quarterly projections," he muttered at his reflection. "Vertical integration. Synergy optimization."

The words tasted like drywall.

"You're talking to yourself again." Nancy appeared in the doorway, already dressed in gallery-chic, already halfway into her

own day.

"Big presentation today."

"You said that yesterday." She met his eyes in the mirror. "And the day before. And the day before that."

He straightened his tie with mechanical precision, each small adjustment betraying a growing irritation with the corporate uniform he'd spent fifteen years earning the right to wear. Nancy watched him a beat longer than usual, then went to deal with her lipstick and her phone, which was already buzzing with gallery business. In the kitchen the coffee maker gurgled to life, steam rising like the morning fog outside. Another day in the machine, warming up.

Except the machine, this particular morning, had developed a slight rattle.



Sunlight streamed through the kitchen windows, illuminating the demilitarized zone where Nancy's artsy decorating touches met Derek's meticulously organized everything. Nancy poured coffee with one hand and answered her phone with the other.

"Sophie? What do you mean the Rothschild piece is delayed?" A pause. Her free hand found her temple. "No, we need it for tonight's opening... The artist is *where?*"

Behind her, the toaster—an appliance with no history of ambition—suddenly launched both slices of toast high into the air, with a violence that could only be described as enthusiastic.

Derek caught both pieces without looking up from his tablet.

Nancy stopped mid-conversation and stared at him. He continued reading, buttering, entirely unaware that he'd just performed a small miracle of hand-eye coordination.

"Since when are you David Copperfield?" she said, covering the phone.

"Magic's all about timing, baby." He turned a page. "Speaking of which—can you grab dinner tonight? The board wants to review the Q3 projections again."

Nancy returned to the phone. "No, Sophie, not you... Yes, I know it's the centerpiece... Just—handle it." She hung up and exhaled. "Actually, I might be late too. Gallery crisis."

"Ah. The classic 'my art will be ready when it's ready' crisis?"

"More like 'my art is currently in a Tahitian jail' crisis."

They gathered briefcases and travel mugs in the practiced synchronization of two people who had been sharing a kitchen for a decade, and headed for the door.

They passed it every morning: the large framed photograph that dominated one wall of the living room. Young Derek—five years old, all ears and elbows—sitting on Sam's lap backstage at the Comedy Store, both of them caught mid-laugh, Sam's beret slightly askew, his arm around his little cousin like a seatbelt against the whole world. The family had all called him Uncle Sam, cousin or not; some people are simply uncles by force of personality. Derek kept a miniature of the same photo on his office desk, where it had long ago become invisible to him, the way anything does when you look at it every day without seeing it.

But this morning, his eyes lingered on Sam's face a moment longer than usual.

The photo, being a photo, did not wink back.

Probably.



The Tesla crawled along the bay with the rest of the morning traffic, fog clinging to the city's shoulders like a damp security blanket. A BMW cut across two lanes without signaling, missing their bumper by a coat of paint.

"Thanks for the signal, pal," Derek said under his breath—and then he laughed. Except it wasn't his laugh. It was raw and untamed, half growl, half delight, the kind of laugh that starts in the chest and ends somewhere in the back row.

Nancy looked up from her phone. "What was that?"

"What was what?"

"That laugh. It sounded just like..." She trailed off, shook her head, and went back to her email. Some sentences are better left unparked.

Derek's knuckles whitened on the wheel. His phone rang; the dashboard display lit up: CHARLES WEBER — CEO. He let it ring. It rang again: OFFICE — VP SALES. Also ignored. The parade of incoming calls had all the subtlety of a laugh track.

"Rerouting due to traffic," the GPS announced, with the serene confidence of a machine that has never once been stuck on Van Ness.

The new route took them down a street Derek hadn't driven in years, past the old Comic Strip club—boarded up now, its windows blind, its faded marquee still stubbornly legible after three decades of fog and neglect:

COMING SOON — SAM KINISON — APRIL 1992

Coming soon. The words hung there, a promise the universe had never gotten around to canceling. Derek's eyes stayed on the marquee longer than they should have, long enough that Nancy glanced over.

The radio crackled with static. And underneath the static—faint, impossible, unmistakable to anyone who had grown up with it echoing through family barbecues—a laugh. *That* laugh. Three rising notes of pure comic detonation.

Derek reached over and snapped the radio off. In the rearview mirror, just for an instant, the face looking back at him wore a beret.

He adjusted the mirror. Just fog. Just traffic. Just a man driving his wife to work on an ordinary Thursday that happened to be the anniversary of the day comedy lost its loudest voice.

Nancy, oblivious, was scrolling through gallery photos. "That new piece I mentioned? It's a painting of this incredible 1900s mansion in Cape Cod. Reminds me of that inn we were looking at up the coast."

"Mm," Derek said, from somewhere else entirely.

"Earth to Derek?" She studied him. "You've been somewhere else all morning."

"Just... thinking about changes."

"Changes?" Her eyes narrowed with the precision of a woman appraising a suspect provenance. "Derek Kinison, are you having an early midlife crisis?"

"Crisis implies I don't know what I'm doing." The timing on the line was immaculate. It wasn't entirely his.

Overhead, thunder rumbled through a cloudless sky, and neither of them mentioned it.



La Pierre Gallery rose out of the streetscape in glass and steel, looking exactly like the kind of place where art went to be taken seriously. Derek pulled up to the curb. Through the gallery

windows, art handlers were easing a crate open—glimpses of an ornate golden frame visible through the slats.

Nancy gathered her things, checked her tablet one final time, then leaned over and kissed his cheek, lingering a moment as she studied his distant expression in the rearview mirror.

"Remember, dinner at seven? I should be done with the new installation by then."

Derek was staring forward, his hands gripping the wheel with unnecessary force. "Sure. Yeah. Seven."

She got out, heels clicking decisively on the concrete, and turned back once—concern crossing her face as she watched her husband not quite watch her go. Then she was gone, swallowed by the glass doors and the Rothschild crisis and the ordinary machinery of her day.

Derek sat at the curb a moment longer than he needed to. Through the gallery's front window, he could see the handlers lifting the new piece free of its crate: a Victorian mansion on a coastal cliff, all turrets and shadows and windows like knowing eyes. Cape Cod, Nancy had said. It didn't look like Cape Cod. It looked like an appointment. He couldn't have said why the shadow it cast seemed, from this angle, to be shaped a little like a man in a beret.

The light changed. The Tesla merged back into traffic, carrying Derek Kinison toward a corporate tower, a boardroom, and slide number forty-seven of a presentation that would change everything.

Somewhere—in whatever cosmic comedy club the dead legends hang out in—somebody was checking the mic.

The morning was just getting started. And the universe, patient as any good comic, was setting up its punchline.

CHAPTER 2

HOW TO DO A CORPORATE MELTDOWN

The lobby of Global Dynamics Marketing looked like what would happen if an architect was asked to design purgatory, given an unlimited budget, and told to make it inspirational. Everything gleamed in that particular shade of off-white that screamed *we paid too much for this*. Motivational posters lined the walls, each more aggressively uplifting than the last. SYNERGY IS SUCCESS, proclaimed the largest, in a font that had never once been funny.

Derek nodded to the security desk on autopilot, a gesture so rehearsed he probably performed it in his sleep. The elevator arrived with a cheerful ding that felt, this morning, like mockery.

Inside, he was alone with his reflection in the polished steel doors. Except he wasn't, quite. The face looking back had his features, but the expression—that wild-eyed, delighted, slightly dangerous grin—belonged to somebody else. Derek blinked hard, the way people do when they're trying to reset either their vision or their entire reality.

His reflection tilted its head. Just the way Sam used to, right before launching into one of his legendary rants. And then it mouthed something. Three syllables. Rising.

The doors opened before Derek could decide whether he'd actually seen it, and the executive floor swallowed him whole—a maze of cubicles that would have made Kafka reach for something stronger than coffee. Young executives whispered their presentations into reflective surfaces like monks rehearsing corporate liturgy. *Our Q4 projections show significant upside potential...*

Charles Weber materialized out of the maze, tablet in hand, moving with the caffeinated polish of a CEO who had long ago replaced sleep with quarterly targets. Charles wasn't a bad man. That was the complicated part. He was a good man who had been in the machine so long he'd started to hum at its frequency.

"Big day, Derek. Board's expecting something revolutionary."

"Revolutionary?" Derek's head tilted—that tilt again. "Is that what we're calling PowerPoint these days?"

Charles laughed, a half-second too late and a half-note too high. "There's the Kinison humor. Just like your cousin, right?"

Derek's smile faltered. Somewhere—fifty floors up, indoors, impossibly—thunder rumbled.

His office was the museum of a successful life: awards, certifications, framed proof that Derek Kinison had done everything right. And on the desk, small enough to ignore, the photograph. Five-year-old Derek on Sam's lap, both of them mid-laugh at something the camera never caught. The miniature twin of the one at home. He'd walked past both of them ten thousand times.

He picked it up. He couldn't have said why.

"Board room in five, Mr. Kinison!" his secretary called.

Derek set the photo down, straightened his tie—too tight, suddenly—loosened it, tightened it again. In the window's reflection, for just a moment, a man in a business suit and a beret straightened his own tie mockingly, a metal button gleaming on his lapel. Derek didn't look closely enough to read it. If he had, it would have said: WELCOME TO THE LAUGH ASYLUM.

He walked to the boardroom. His footsteps seemed to get louder as he went, the ambient office noise fading away until there was only the sound of his own shoes and his own breathing, like the

world was clearing its throat before an announcement.



The boardroom was sleek and modern and dominated by a mahogany table large enough to declare war on. Floor-to-ceiling windows offered a panoramic view of San Francisco that nobody ever looked at. On the screen, slides full of graphs and jargon glowed with the confidence of numbers that had been massaged until they relaxed.

Derek sat rigidly, laptop open, sweat beginning at his hairline as the voices around him blurred into a single corporate drone.

"And as you can see from the quarterly projections," Charles was saying, "our vertical integration strategy..."

Derek's hands began to tremble. Fifteen years of these meetings. Fifteen years of nodding at slides. Somewhere in his chest, something was pulling tight—a guitar string winding past its tuning.

"Does anyone here know," he said, quietly, "who my uncle Sam was?"

The room fell silent. A field of confused faces, most of them belonging to executives who hadn't been born yet when Sam died.

A young exec leaned toward his colleague. "Who's Uncle Sam?"

The colleague shrugged. "Some old comedian, I think?"

Some old comedian.

Something snapped. Not broke—snapped. Like the string finally going, like a comedian finding his voice after a fifteen-year sound check.

"SOME OLD COMEDIAN?" Derek was on his feet, his chair rolling back with a sound like thunder. And then it *was*

thunder—real thunder, rattling the windows fifty floors above the street, under a sky the forecast had sworn was clear. The lights flickered. "OH! OH! OHHHH!"

The scream came out of him fully formed, three rising notes of pure detonation, a sound Derek Kinison had never made in his life and had somehow been rehearsing since 1992.

The room sat frozen. Then, because corporate instinct dies harder than dignity, the VP of Sales cleared his throat and attempted a rescue: "As you can see from slide forty-seven, our vertical integration strategy—"

"If we leverage our synergistic opportunities—" another exec began.

Each buzzword landed on Derek like a heckle. His tie came all the way loose and hung there like a surrender flag—except Derek had never felt less like surrendering in his life.

"My cousin Sam used to SCREAM his comedy into existence," he said, and his voice wasn't entirely his own anymore—it was rawer, bigger, truer. "Everybody thought he was crazy." He laughed, that wild laugh from the car, and it filled the room in a way the acoustic paneling was specifically engineered to prevent. "He wasn't crazy. He just saw through all the—" he gestured at the glowing slides like he was shooing away flies, "—THIS!"

"Derek." Charles's voice had gone very calm, the tone of a man talking someone off a ledge he had personally helped build. "Maybe you should take a moment to—"

But Derek was past moments. He walked over to Charles and slowly leaned down, head tilted at that angle that belonged on a stage, and when he spoke it was a perfect Kinison impression—pitch, cadence, and detonation—that made several executives physically jump.

"You ever wonder why we do all this crap? Why we act like uppity important executives while hard-working people went over to Vietnam up to their necks in rice paddies, shooting those North Korean gooks, giving their lives—so we can make some PowerPoint presentation? OH! OH! OHHHHHHH!"

The lights flickered again. Through the windows, storm clouds were assembling over a city that had been promised sunshine.

"Fifteen years!" Derek was building now, riding the crescendo. "Fifteen years of PowerPoints and synergy and vertical integration! For WHAT?!" He tore his tie the rest of the way off and threw it onto the mahogany like a gauntlet. "To sit here pretending any of this matters?"

Maureen Hamlin, VP of Client Relations, rose halfway out of her chair with the nervous grace of a hostage negotiator. "Derek, let's just take a breath and—"

"No, Maureen." Derek's voice dropped into an eerie calm, which was somehow louder than the screaming. "No more breaths. No more meetings. No more... whatever this is." He gestured at the room, the screen, the entire fluorescent ecosystem. "I'm done."

Somewhere in the office beyond the glass walls, somebody snorted. Somebody else didn't quite suppress a laugh. The young exec who'd said *some old comedian* was staring at Derek with the expression of a man watching his first live comedy show and his first workplace incident simultaneously.

"Derek," Charles tried again, "think about your future. Your security—"

"Security." Derek said the word like it was the punchline he'd been building to his whole life. "I spent fifteen years building a fortress out of security, Charles. Mortgage. Retirement plan. Dental. And you know what I found when I finished building it?" He picked up his laptop, closed it gently, almost tenderly, like closing a casket.

"I was inside."

He walked to the door. Stopped. Turned—because some exits are genetic—and gave the room a deep, theatrical bow. Sam's bow, executed to the millimeter.

"I quit. And by the way—" he pointed at the screen, at slide forty-seven, still glowing faithfully, "—your projections are wrong. They're ALWAYS wrong."



Packing a career into a cardboard box takes less time than the career suggests it should. Awards. Certifications. The little framed photo of Sam, which went in last, face up.

Derek's phone buzzed the entire time, the notifications stacking like a laugh track: *Meeting in chaos. Did you just QUIT? HR needs to speak with you immediately. LinkedIn: 25 people viewed your profile.*

And then one more, from Charles: *Think about your future, Derek. About security. About what matters.*

Derek laughed out loud—that laugh again—alone in his office with a box. Because that was exactly the point, wasn't it? He *was* finally thinking about what mattered. It had just taken a dead comedian and a public meltdown to schedule the meeting.

He hoisted the box and found his secretary standing at the office door, defensive and nervous, a woman whose job description had not covered this.

"What do you want me to do, Mr. Kinison?"

Derek turned to her in what felt like slow motion, wearing a smile that was warm and wild in equal parts. "You can take the rest of the day off. Get yourself a manicure. Maybe grab some lunch at Jake's Boathouse Bar and Grill. And after lunch, catch a matinee—I hear they're showing an old classic. 'Savage Dawn.'" He let out that

laugh again, the one that had been escaping all morning.

At the elevator, he stepped in, turned, and—as the doors began to close on fifteen years of his life—delivered his exit line with a creepy, beatific, entirely Sam-like smile:

"Daddy's on sabbatical!"

Down in the lobby, security personnel were already murmuring urgently into their radios—"He's here... sir, we need you to exit the building"—as Derek crossed the marble with his box, entirely unhurried. Marcus—the security guard who had nodded to Derek every morning for a decade without either of them really seeing the other—looked up from his desk.

"You okay there, Mr. Kinison?"

Derek stopped. Actually looked at him. "You know something, Marcus? I don't think I've been okay for fifteen years." He shifted the box to one hip. "But I'm starting to be."

The lobby's ambient music system chose that exact moment to shuffle onto a new track, and the opening riff of "Wild Thing" came grinding out of speakers that normally dispensed nothing stronger than smooth jazz. Marcus frowned at the ceiling. Derek just grinned and pushed through the revolving doors, and as he stepped out into the San Francisco morning, he could have sworn he heard a familiar voice riding under the music:

About time you woke up, cousin. About time.



In the parking garage, Derek put the box in the trunk, sat in the driver's seat, and gripped the wheel until his knuckles went white. The adrenaline was draining now, leaving behind the arithmetic: no job, one mortgage, a wife at a gallery who didn't yet know her husband had detonated his career before ten a.m.

"What the hell did I just do?" he whispered to the rearview mirror.

The face looking back wore an expression that was equal parts terror and exhilaration. "What the hell did I just do?" he asked it again—and this time the question came out as a laugh. Sam's laugh. It filled the car like a prophecy.

His phone lit up one more time. Not the office. His home security app: *Unusual activity detected — master bedroom mirror, camera glitch, review footage?* Derek almost dismissed it. Then he saw the timestamp.

5:45 a.m.

The exact minute his alarm had introduced the anniversary of Sam Kinison's death.

Derek stared at the notification for a long moment. Then he put the phone face-down on the passenger seat, started the car, and pulled out into traffic.

He needed to see Nancy.

Behind him, the Global Dynamics tower shrank in the mirror, fifty floors of security getting smaller and smaller until it could have fit in a cardboard box.

CHAPTER 3

THE BIG ASK

The Tesla screeched to a halt in a no-parking zone outside La Pierre Gallery, and Derek jumped out, leaving the hazard lights blinking like a warning to the city at large: *unstable man, handle with care*.

Inside, the gallery was all high ceilings and white walls and the hush of expensive taste. Nancy stood with a client in front of a large painting—the new piece, freshly uncrated that morning. A Victorian mansion on a coastal cliff, rendered in oils, its windows dark and somehow attentive.

"The artist captured the Victorian architecture's—" Nancy's professional voice died mid-sentence. "Derek? What are you doing here?"

"Remember that inn?" The words came out breathless, tumbling over each other.

"What inn?"

He was already pulling out his phone, hands shaking with an energy he couldn't have suppressed if he'd wanted to. On the screen: a real estate listing. A majestic but weathered Victorian mansion perched on a clifftop, its widow's walk reaching toward the sky like a raised finger making a point about life's absurdities.

"The one in Northern California. The one we talked about maybe a year ago. I found it. It's still for sale. It's perfect, Nancy. It's absolutely perfect."

Nancy looked at the phone. Then at her husband, who was supposed to be fifty floors up in a boardroom. Then back at the phone. "Would you excuse me for a moment?" she said to the client,

and pulled Derek aside with the grip of a woman who has handled priceless objects and knows exactly how much pressure to apply.

"Derek. Are you okay? Why aren't you at work?"

"Twenty-five rooms. Ocean view. History. It needs work, sure, but Nancy—Nancy, *look* at it."

She took the phone. Her eyes widened as she scrolled: sweeping ocean views, ornate architecture, rooms that were weathered but underneath it all, elegant. Behind them, the client awkwardly pretended to study the painting, which happened to depict a mansion remarkably like the one currently changing the trajectory of the Kinison-Hammond household.

"Derek." Realization was dawning across her face like a weather system. "Did you just quit your job? Are you having some midlife crisis or something?"

"Oh yeah. Big time. Like, nuclear-explosion big time." He laughed—and there it was again, that laugh. "I may have channeled a bit of my uncle Sam."

"Sam? Your cousin Sam?" She lowered the phone. "Derek, you haven't talked about him in years."

"I know. For some reason I started thinking about him when I got up this morning. About us. About our dream of getting out of this rat-race, superficial life we're living—"

"Derek, you're scaring me, babe. This is so not you." She took his hand and led him into her office, closing the door on the gallery's curious silence. "I'm sure Charles will overlook this. You can go back after a couple of days off to reset yourself."

"Nancy. Look at me." He held her eyes, and whatever she saw there made her stop rehearsing her next sensible sentence. "I'm not nuts. I'm not hysterical. In fact, I think I'm seeing things clearer than I have in a long time."

Through the office window, the mansion painting stared back at them both, its windows like knowing eyes.

"Our savings," Nancy said quietly. "The mortgage. Derek, this is insane."

"Maybe insane is exactly what we need. When was the last time either of us felt truly alive?"

The question sat there between them, and neither of them reached to move it, because they both knew the answer had a date on it, and the date was embarrassing.

"I know it's weird," Derek said, quieter now. "But seeing this place again, thinking about Uncle Sam... it all just clicked. We've been talking about leaving the city for years. Maybe starting a family. About doing something different."

Nancy studied his face the way she studied a canvas when she suspected there was another painting underneath. Then she looked at the listing again. Her art dealer's eye moved across the photographs—the bones of the place, the light, the possibility.

"It's beautiful, but—"

"But what if we did it?" He couldn't stop now; the words had been in cold storage for fifteen years and they were all thawing at once. "What if we just—*did* it? No more corporate meetings, no more goddamn PowerPoint presentations, no more gallery politics. Just us, making something ours. We're not getting any younger!"

Nancy looked from the phone to Derek and back again. And then something happened that no quarterly projection could have predicted: a smile began to creep across her face. The old smile. The one from before the mortgage.

She opened the office door, walked straight to the client—who was by now on very intimate terms with the mansion painting—and said, "I am so sorry, but we're going to need to reschedule. Family

emergency." She turned toward the front desk. "Sophie, can you clear my schedule for the rest of the day?"

Derek had followed her out and was standing a few feet away with the expression of a man watching a coin land. "Does that mean...?"

"It means you're driving me home so I can change, and then we're driving up the coast to look at this place before I come to my senses." She fixed him with a look that had closed six-figure sales. "But just to *look*. LOOK, only LOOK."

As they pulled away from the gallery, Derek let out another little laugh—that laugh.

"Derek. That laugh again."

"What laugh?"

Nancy turned to answer and decided, on the evidence of the last three hours, that some questions were better saved for the drive.

Somewhere behind them, thunder rumbled over a perfectly sunny city.

Somewhere ahead of them, two hours up the coast, a mansion that had been waiting thirty-three years adjusted its shadows and put the coffee on.

CHAPTER 4

THE DRIVE NORTH

The coastal highway unspooled ahead of them, the Pacific glittering to the left, cliffs rising to the right, the afternoon sun casting long shadows that stretched toward the water like they were trying to escape something inland.

Nancy had changed into what she called her "possibly making a terrible decision" outfit and spent the first hour alternating between the listing photos and increasingly practical questions—inspection contingencies, septic systems, what exactly one does with twenty-five rooms. Derek answered maybe half of them. The other half of his attention was on the road, and on the peculiar feeling that the road already knew where they were going.

Two hours north of San Francisco, the highway narrowed and the world got older. They passed a weathered sign—OCEANVIEW, POP. 2,847—and rolled into a small coastal town that looked like it had been art-directed by Edgar Allan Poe on one of his cheerier days. Gothic storefronts. A church steeple black against the gray sky. A diner whose sign read THE LAST LAUGH, its windows papered with old headshots. Storm clouds were gathering over the water despite a forecast that had promised, with the confidence of all forecasts, clear skies.

"Charming," Nancy said, in the tone she used at gallery openings for art she hadn't decided about yet.

"It's got character."

"So did the Bates Motel."

They stopped once for directions and a charge at a gas station attached to a cluttered outdoor supply store—HARRISON'S, said

the sign—where a weathered old-timer named Earl looked at them a beat too long when Derek mentioned the Ravenscrest property, then gave them directions with the careful courtesy of a man handing over a map he wasn't sure he should.

"Big place," was all he offered. "Been waiting on the right folks."

Waiting. Nancy filed the word away.

"They say it used to be a psychiatric hospital in the fifties," Derek offered as they climbed out of town. "The realtor mentioned something about the last owner dying under mysterious circumstances."

"Mysterious circumstances." Nancy let the phrase sit there a moment. "And don't forget—we are only *looking*. Right?"

"Sure. Don't worry about it. Place this old is bound to have some stories."

They passed a weathered sign, half swallowed by blackberry bramble: RAVENCREST PSYCHIATRIC HOSPITAL — CLOSED 1975.

Thunder crashed, considerably closer than the forecast.

The road to the mansion wound up through cypress and fog, and then the trees opened, and there it was.

Ravenscrest revealed itself the way a curtain reveals a stage: all at once, and with intent. The Victorian colossus rose three imposing stories on the cliff's edge, its central mass flanked by two-story wings that sprawled outward like embracing arms, half consumed by creeping vines. Paint peeled from ornate trim like skin shedding its past. Loose shutters tapped irregular rhythms against weathered siding. And crowning it all, the widow's walk perched atop the roofline like a raised eyebrow, keeping watch over the Pacific.

The overall effect was of a building caught between grandeur and surrender—as if the mansion itself hadn't decided whether to

stand proud or give in to time. Looking at it, Derek had the distinct impression it had been holding that pose for a long while now, waiting for an audience worth the effort.

And high on the widow's walk, where nobody in the car could possibly have seen it, a silhouette stood against the darkening sky—beret, wild hair, a stance last photographed backstage at the Comedy Store—and said, to no one and to everyone:

"About time you showed up, cousin. We've got work to do..."

"A fixer-upper might be an understatement," Nancy said, her art dealer's eye cataloguing every failing joint and every opportunity in the same pass.

A FOR SALE sign creaked in the rising wind, its paint nearly as faded as the mansion's. Below it hung a smaller, newer sign: LINDA RHODES — COASTAL DREAMS REALTY. The sign swayed. There was no breeze.

"You said the realtor's meeting us here?"

"Should be. Though I may have been a bit... impulsive with the timing."

"You? Impulsive? Today?"

As if summoned, a sleek Mercedes materialized behind them, headlights flaring in the rearview like predatory eyes. LINDA RHODES emerged—fifties, perfectly coiffed, wearing a suit that cost more than the FOR SALE sign's remaining lifespan—and checked her watch with the barely concealed annoyance of a woman whose afternoon had just been rescheduled by the universe.

"Mr. and Mrs. Kinison!" Her brightness had the wattage of a showroom. "I wasn't expecting you quite so... soon."

"Actually, it's Hammond," Derek said. "She kept her name."

"Of course, of course." The recovery was smooth, professional, instant. "Shall we?"

They started up the walk together. The mansion loomed larger with every step, in a way that didn't feel entirely explainable by geometry. Thunder rumbled out over the water—the sky's third editorial comment of the day—and somewhere high above them, a shutter tapped twice, almost politely, like a stage manager calling places.

Nancy, bringing up the rear, noticed something the brochure hadn't mentioned: Linda's hands were shaking, ever so slightly, as she sorted through her keys.

CHAPTER 5

THE GRAND TOUR

The front doors opened onto a foyer built for arrivals that mattered.

Dust motes danced in shafts of light from tall windows. A massive crystal chandelier hung overhead—precariously, Nancy judged—casting prismatic patterns through the dust like the ghost of a party that hadn't quite ended. The wallpaper, though faded, revealed itself on second look to be an intricate pattern of ravens in flight, hundreds of them, all heading somewhere with great purpose.

Their footsteps echoed on ancient hardwood, past a large area rug that occupied the center of the foyer with a precision Nancy's eye registered before her brain did.

"That's Doctor Harrison Blackwood," Linda said, indicating the massive portrait dominating the far wall: a stern Victorian gentleman beside an ornate chair, rendered by an artist who had clearly been instructed to make the eyes follow visitors. The eyes followed visitors. "He founded the sanatorium here in 1952."

"Something familiar about him..." Nancy said, studying the face.

"Vincent Price," said Derek. "He looks like Vincent Price."

"Good eye." Linda seemed genuinely impressed. "Doctor Blackwood actually consulted on 'House on Haunted Hill.' They modeled the asylum owner after him."

Derek's phone buzzed. CHARLES WEBER — CEO. He silenced it.

"The previous owner, Mr. Rhodes—no relation—was quite the collector."

"Collector of what, exactly?" Nancy's art dealer instincts had fully deployed.

"Oh, this and that. Shall we see the kitchen first?"

But Nancy had already drifted to a display case against the wall, and what was inside it did not qualify, under any professional definition she knew, as *this and that*. A ventriloquist dummy that looked eerily like Charlie McCarthy, wearing a tiny beret. Beside it, a worn straitjacket, folded with what could only be called reverence. An antique electroshock machine, its dials still set to something. And perched atop a human skull, a stuffed raven, its glass eyes catching the chandelier light.

"Is this... original?" Nancy asked.

"The dummy's from a lost episode of *The Twilight Zone*. The skull's plastic." A pause that ran exactly one beat too long. "I think."

Derek, meanwhile, had drifted to an umbrella stand holding a single black umbrella with a carved raven handle. "Mary Poppins gone gothic?"

"The Penguin's' umbrella. Danny DeVito used it in *'Batman Returns'*."

Beside the stand hung an old black-and-white photograph: the mansion in its heyday, crisp and proud—RAVENCREST PSYCHIATRIC HOSPITAL, 1955. Derek leaned in. In an upper window, small but unmistakable, a figure seemed to be wearing a familiar beret.

He was still staring at it when Nancy's attention went to the floor.

The area rug had shifted—one corner curled back just enough to reveal dark red paint beneath, a curved line of it worked into the hardwood. Nancy crouched, and her curator's hands moved before her manners could object, folding the corner back a few more

inches. The red line continued. Joined another. Became geometry. Became, unmistakably, the arc and angle of a painted pentagram, its lines laid down with a draftsman's care.

"These markings..." She traced the air above them without touching. "The precision of this line work—this isn't random vandalism. Look how the geometry aligns with the mansion's architectural features." She caught herself. "Sorry. Occupational habit."

Linda moved between Nancy and the rug with remarkable speed for a woman in heels. "Just some YouTube ghost hunters playing pranks. I've called Mr. Larry Leland—the property maintenance man—to clean it up." Her brightness reasserted itself by force. "The kitchen has original fixtures..."

Derek wasn't listening. He was looking up. "The crown moulding. The patterns repeat up there too."

They did. The same geometric lines threaded subtly through the mansion's architectural details—cornices, medallions, the chandelier's mounting—an intricate network laced through the whole structure, all of it seeming to radiate outward from whatever lay beneath that rug.

Nancy and Derek exchanged a look, both noting the same detail: Linda stepped carefully *around* the covered symbol rather than across it, and her movement appeared almost unconscious.

Thunder crashed—from *inside* the house. The chandelier crystals tinkled ominously overhead, and for a moment the dust motes in the air seemed to arrange themselves into familiar patterns before dispersing.



The kitchen was a massive space that somehow managed to feel both industrial and homey. Copper pots hung from ceiling racks

like stalactites, their polished surfaces catching light from tall windows. An ancient AGA stove dominated one wall, its multiple ovens suggesting dinner parties of considerable ambition. And on one counter sat a peculiar mechanical coffee maker—all brass and glass tubes, less kitchen appliance than Victorian laboratory apparatus.

"Was Mr. Rhodes a chef?" Derek asked, noting the professional layout.

Linda glanced at the stove with what looked, briefly, like nervousness. "He... entertained. The kitchen was used for various... performances."

A copper pot chose that moment to clang to the floor between them.

Everyone jumped. The brass coffee maker gurgled to life unprompted, steam rising through its tubes in rhythmic puffs, like a small engine warming up for something.

"Oh dear." Linda was checking her phone with increasing urgency. "I'm getting another call about the LA buyers—"

"LA buyers?" Nancy said.

"Just some interested parties. Nothing to worry about. Though they *are* offering cash..."

Nancy wandered to the massive refrigerator, its chrome Art Deco finish reflecting their distorted images, and opened it out of pure curiosity. She pulled out a milk carton. "Like this milk being fresh after six months?"

All three of them stared at the carton. The date stamped on it was today's.

"I... showed the place yesterday," Linda managed. "Someone must have—"

"To who?" Derek asked.

"Whom."

They all turned. Nobody had spoken.

The kitchen fell into an extremely uncomfortable silence, broken only by the coffee maker's continued gurgling and the distant grammar of the storm. Derek looked at Nancy. Nancy looked at Derek. Linda looked at her phone as if it might offer an extraction plan.

"Shall we see the upper floor?" she said, too brightly.

As they filed out, the coffee maker completed its work and produced, with a small triumphant hiss, one perfect cup of coffee. The steam rose off it in a lazy curl that, for just a moment, held the unmistakable shape of a beret.

Nobody was there to see it. Which was probably the point.



The second-floor hallway was lined with vintage movie posters—*Psycho*, *The Haunting*, *House on Haunted Hill*, *The Pit and the Pendulum*, and, inexplicably, *The Goonies*—each one seeming to glow faintly in the gray light filtering through rain-streaked windows.

Derek's phone buzzed again. Voicemail. He put it to his ear and began triaging.

"Derek, it's Charles. The board wants to discuss—" *Delete*. "Derek, about this morning—" *Delete*. "This is completely unlike you—" *Delete*.

The last message began to play.

"OH! OH! OHHHHH! Remember what I always said, cousin? Life's too short for corporate BS!"

Derek dropped the phone.

It clattered on the hardwood and lay there, screen up, innocent. *Unknown number*. Nancy and Linda had walked ahead; neither had heard. Derek picked the phone up with two fingers, like it might still be hot, and checked the voicemail list.

There were three messages. All from Charles.

He put the phone in his pocket and did not check it again, and they walked on past a door with a small brass plate reading HYDROTHERAPY, through which an ancient copper bathtub was partially visible.

It had restraints.

"Original fixtures," Linda said, without slowing down.



The library made Nancy stop breathing for a second, the way certain rooms did.

Floor-to-ceiling bookshelves. A rolling ladder. A desk that could have belonged to Hemingway, if Hemingway had been slightly more organized. Outside the tall windows, storm clouds continued their impossible gathering while the sun, elsewhere, went on shining.

"These are first editions..." Nancy was already at the shelves, fingers hovering over spines with the professional restraint of someone who wanted very badly to touch everything.

She pulled a leather-bound volume free, dust cascading off its spine like ancient memories breaking loose. She read the cover aloud.

"Comedy in the Raw — by Sam Kinison."

The room went very quiet.

Her art dealer's eye caught the details in rapid succession: pristine condition despite apparent age. Publication date, April 1992—the month Sam died.

"That's impossible," Derek whispered. He took the book with hands that were not quite steady. "Sam never wrote a book. Everyone knew that. He always said his words weren't meant for paper—they needed air and sound and fury."

Before he could open it, Linda appeared beside him—from where, exactly, was unclear—and snatched the volume away with surprising force.

"Most of these will be going to auction, of course," she said quickly, her manicured nails digging into the cover.

But Derek had already seen enough. The author photo on the back showed Sam in his signature beret—and the background, unmistakably, was Ravenscrest's widow's walk.

Derek's eye caught a door behind the desk, old wood, older hinges. "Where does that lead?"

"Oh, that's just storage. Nothing interesting." Too quick. Much too quick. "Now, about the asking price..."

Linda exited with the practiced stride of a tour guide who knows when to move things along. Derek and Nancy stayed.

Nancy retrieved the Sam Kinison book from the shelf where Linda had jammed it and opened it at random while Derek circled the room. The pipe organ—there was apparently a pipe organ, somewhere deep in the house—sent a few faint notes drifting through the walls, unhurried, like someone noodling before a show.

"Listen to this," Nancy said, and read: "Comedy isn't just about making people laugh. It's about making them feel something real."

She looked up at Derek, who was examining an old comedy club poster on the wall.

"You know, I never told you this, but my parents once saw Sam perform. Right before he died."

Derek turned, genuinely surprised. "You never mentioned that."

"It was at the Comic Strip. I was like four. They told me the story later—I think when we were just starting to date. They said he was... raw. Scary, almost. But *authentic*." A beat. "Like you were today."

"Nancy, if this is too much—"

"When we met, you had that same fire." She closed the book, but kept her hand on the cover. "Then somewhere between mortgages and meetings, we both lost something." She looked around the library—the books, the dust, the storm-light. "Maybe this place... maybe it's not just about Sam finding you today."

Thunder rumbled, closer now. Through the window, up on the widow's walk, a figure stood against the darkening sky. Wearing a beret.

Neither of them saw it. They were looking at each other.

"Maybe it's about us finding ourselves again," Nancy said.



The master bedroom was dominated by a massive four-poster bed, its dark wood gleaming despite years of neglect—as if the dust had simply declined to settle there. Bay windows overlooked the ocean, where the waves were growing taller as the storm assembled itself offshore.

"Derek, look at this view..." Nancy stood at the huge window, and for a moment the practical questions fell entirely silent.

Derek wasn't looking at the view. He was looking at the vanity mirror.

It reflected the room, as mirrors do. Except that for one long, impossible second, the room it reflected wasn't this one. Same walls, same windows—but hospital beds in rows, and medical equipment, and light the color of 1955.

He blinked. Four-poster bed. Bay windows. Dust.

"Did you see—?"

"We need to talk about the gallery," Nancy said, still at the window, already three moves ahead on a different board.

Linda's phone rang from the hallway. "Excuse me," she called, and stepped out to answer it, her voice dropping to a register the acoustics weren't supposed to carry. It carried anyway, in fragments: *both interested... tonight... yes, I understand.*

Thunder crashed, closer now. The lights flickered.

"Derek, I can't just abandon the gallery. We have the Warhol exhibition next month—"

"Take three months. If it doesn't work..."

"You said you channeled your dead cousin in a board meeting!" Her voice climbed into the register she reserved for insurance adjusters and acts of God. "You *screamed* at the CEO about *Vietnam!*"

Thunder rumbled its agreement. Somewhere deep in the mansion, a door slammed.

Derek looked back at the mirror. It showed him a bedroom, a wife, and a man who had woken up that morning owning a career and would go to sleep tonight owning, at minimum, a question.

Outside, the storm settled in over the Pacific like an audience taking its seats.



Linda reappeared in the doorway with her composure freshly reapplied, and steered them down to the parlor, where they settled into dusty Victorian chairs while she rifled through papers, the storm light turning the room the color of an old photograph.

"Now, full disclosure," she said, in the tone realtors use when the disclosure is going to be anything but full. "The property has had several... interesting chapters. The psychiatric hospital, of course. Then a brief period as a comedy club, in the late eighties..."

Derek sat forward. "A comedy club?"

"The Laugh Asylum." Linda's mouth pinched, as if the name had a taste. "Rather tasteless, really. It closed after—"

Thunder CRASHED, and the lights went out completely.

In the blackness, lightning strobed once through the tall windows, and in that single frame Derek saw a figure standing in the corner—wild hair, beret—there and gone. And where the figure had stood, the wall now held a framed poster he would have sworn hadn't been there when they sat down: "Back to School," Rodney Dangerfield poised on the high board, about to attempt the Triple Lindy.

"Perhaps we should continue this tomorrow." Linda was already standing. "The storm..."

"But we drove all the way from San Francisco," Nancy said.

"I insist. The roads can be treacherous after dark. And I have a strict policy about never showing the property after sunset. It's purely a safety issue—you understand, I'm sure."

As if taking its cue, the sun dropped below the horizon, and the parlor went from dim to nearly black, holding only a last blue-gray wash of dusk in the windows.



Linda didn't walk them to their car so much as herd them to it. Behind them, in a house with no power, a light came on in the widow's walk.

"I'll have the paperwork ready first thing tomorrow. Though the LA buyers are supposed to be here tomorrow morning at some point... Why don't you stay in town overnight? We can finish everything in the morning."

"We didn't really bring anything with us," Nancy said. "We thought this was a day trip."

"Well then." Linda's anxiety was showing through the lacquer now. "The local motel will have everything you need, and the diner's open for another hour. It should work out perfectly for you."

"We'll take it," Derek said.

It came out of him without consultation, and nobody present mistook it for a comment about the motel.

"Derek!"

"We'll take it. We'll pay the asking price."

Nancy stepped smoothly in front of the sentence before it could sign anything. "Linda—what Derek *means* is, we'll discuss it tonight. And assuming there are no issues, why don't you draw up the offer papers for us to sign in the morning—subject to financing. But we really do need to discuss this tonight, ourselves. Assuming that works for you?"

"Wonderful." Linda's smile did not reach her eyes, or indeed very far past her teeth. "Just... don't come back after dark. Not until the paperwork is final."

They drove away. In the rearview mirror, Linda stood watching them go, and above her, the light in the widow's walk went dark.



"*We'll take it?*" Nancy let the silence in the car ripen first, which was somehow worse. "What about my two cents, Derek?"

More silence. The uncomfortable kind, with the meter running.

"Three months," she said at last. "That's the deal. But you need to call Charles back. And I'm going to need the odd day at the gallery."

Thunder crashed behind them. Lightning lit the mansion up in the mirrors—and in an upstairs window, the "Back to School" poster had been replaced by one for "Young Frankenstein," Marty Feldman eyeing Teri Garr over the caption "Nice Knockers."

Neither of them saw it. Which, given the negotiation they had just concluded, was probably for the best.

"Did you see the comedy book?" Derek said. "Sam's book. He never wrote a book."

"What are you saying?"

"I'm saying... I think we're supposed to be here."

Far behind them, up on the widow's walk, a figure raised its arms to the storm like a conductor cueing the orchestra—and the sky obliged.

CHAPTER 6

ROOM 237

Evening came down over Oceanview with the storm right behind it, and the town's streets emptied like a theater between shows. Derek and Nancy drove back through the gathering dark, past the shuttered shops and the Last Laugh Diner's glowing windows, until the Oceanview Motel's neon VACANCY sign flickered into view against the storm clouds.

The motel was pure 1960s—well-maintained but dated, a long low building with a lit office at one end, and an overall architectural sensibility that both of them clocked immediately and neither of them said out loud.

"It looks like—" Derek started.

"Don't."

"I'm just saying, if there's a taxidermy section in the office—"

"Don't."

Inside the office, a clerk in his seventies looked up from a dog-eared paperback. The book was "The Shining." Of course it was.

"Just passing through?" His name tag read MR. CRANE.

"Actually, we're buying the old Ravenscrest place, Mr. Crane," Derek said.

"Actually," Nancy inserted herself smoothly, "we MAY be buying the old Ravenscrest place."

The clerk dropped his book.

Derek was already filling out the registration card, and when the old man's eyes fell on the last name—KINISON, in Derek's tidy

corporate print—his face went white. Not surprised-white. *Recognized*-white. For a moment he stared at the card the way a man stares at a bill he'd hoped was lost in the mail.

"Please," he said, recovering with visible effort, "call me Norman." A beat. "Oh... oh my. Haven't had anyone stay out there since... well." Another beat, longer, containing an entire unshared history. "Room 237 okay?"

Derek and Nancy exchanged a look. Room 237. The clerk was named Norman. He was reading "The Shining" in the office of a motel that looked like the Bates. Either the universe was being extremely unsubtle, or the town of Oceanview had a sense of humor with excellent production values.

And underneath the joke, quieter: they couldn't shake the feeling there was something *familiar* about Norman Crane himself—something that tugged at the edge of memory like a half-forgotten dream.

"237 is fine," Nancy said.



The room was standard motel fare: two queen beds, vintage wallpaper, and—Derek discovered with genuine delight—a coin-operated vibrating bed, its little metal box promising VIBRATOR — 5 MINUTES FOR 25 CENTS.

"Look, hon." He sat down on it and patted the mattress. "You won't even need me tonight."

Nancy, cross-legged on the other bed with her laptop open and her phone to her ear, ignored this with the fluency of long practice. "Sophie, I need you to reschedule the Rothschild opening... Yes, I know it's been planned for months..."

Derek wandered to the window and watched the storm come in. Lightning lit the coastline, and there on its cliff, miles off, the

silhouette of Ravencrest stood against the sky—less like a building, from this distance, and more like something alive that was pretending very hard to be a building.

Headlights swept the parking lot. A sleek black SUV with tinted windows rolled slowly past the window, trailed by a black van.

"Nancy..."

She was deep in gallery triage. The SUV parked. Two figures emerged—expensive suits, unhurried, radiating the specific confidence of people whose problems were handled by other people. Hollywood, said every detail of them. They headed for the office.

Derek's phone buzzed. A text from Linda: *LA buyers in town. Meeting tomorrow 9AM. Don't be late.*

Nancy hung up and exhaled. "The gallery can survive three months. But Derek—this has to work."

Thunder crashed. The room's lights flickered.

"It will. It's like..." He searched for the sentence and found only the true one. "It's like Sam is telling me this is right."

"Sam's been gone thirty years, Derek." Her voice was gentle—supportive and practical at the same time, which was Nancy's native register.

"Then why was his book in that library?"

She didn't have an answer for that. Neither did the room.

Through the rain-streaked window, the Hollywood types exited the office with a key, Mr. Crane visible behind them in the doorway making a gesture that looked suspiciously like the sign of the cross. Their key tag caught the light: CABIN 1.

Derek's phone rang. CHARLES WEBER — CEO.

He answered this time. "Charles, I—"

"Board meeting. Tomorrow morning." Charles's voice came through clipped, executive, running the play. "Your job still exists if you want it. Don't make me regret this."

"But Charles," Derek said, in his own voice, his normal voice, the calmest he'd sounded all day, "I quit."

"Nobody quits, Derek." And here Charles's tone changed—the authority draining out of it, replaced by something almost paternal, almost worried. "They take leaves of absence. Mental health sabbaticals. We can spin this. Work with me, buddy."

Thunder crashed directly overhead, and the lights went out completely.

In the strobing lightning through the window, Derek caught a sequence of images, one flash at a time, like slides in a presentation nobody had scheduled:

The Hollywood types entering their cabin.

Linda's Mercedes pulling into the parking lot.

A figure standing motionless in the rain, face hidden, wearing a beret.

And the distant mansion—with a single light burning in the widow's walk.

"Okay, Charles." Derek kept his voice steady. "You have always been both a great boss and a good friend. I need a bit of time, but I'll call you in a day or two to chat. I'm sorry if I was a bit over the top with my speech—"

The phone died. Not the call. The phone—battery gone, screen black, in a device that had been at sixty percent.

Derek looked at the dead screen for a moment, then set it down. Across the room, Nancy's laptop glowed in the dark, its battery

apparently exempt from whatever was happening, her screen full of property documents she'd been pulling all evening—title records, tax history, and something labeled PREVIOUS OWNER DEATH CERTIFICATE.

She squinted at the screen. "Derek. It says here the last owner died on April 10th, 1992."

The room got very still.

"That's..." Derek's voice came out strange. "That's the day Sam died."

Lightning flashed. Thunder crashed. And in the room's mirror, for one full second—not a flicker, not a maybe—Sam's face appeared, clear and bright and grinning like a man who has just watched the setup land perfectly.

"Time to come home, cousin..."

The voice was barely audible under the storm. Nancy, staring at the death certificate, didn't hear it.

Derek did.

He stood in the dark motel room, thirty years and three hundred miles from the last family barbecue where he'd heard that voice, and found that he wasn't scared.

He was, if anything, relieved. Like a man who's been carrying a phone that finally rang.

CHAPTER 7

THE PRICE IS RIGHT

Morning arrived undecided—the sky over Oceanview unable to commit to storm or sunshine, and splitting the difference in shades of pewter.

Derek and Nancy checked out of the Oceanview Motel at 8:22 by the office's ancient wall clock, Mr. Crane counting their change with deliberate, arthritic care, each coin placed like part of a ritual. The door's bell chimed, and in swept Chad Wellington III and Marina St. Clair, trailing designer luggage and the particular air of people who assume every room has been waiting for them.

"Darling, you simply must see the TikTok metrics on haunted properties," Marina was saying into her phone. "They're *insane*."

"Cabin 1, checking out," Chad announced, producing a black credit card with a flourish. "Put it on the Black Card."

Derek and Nancy gathered their things. As they passed:

"Lovely morning," Nancy offered, with a polite smile.

"Oh yes." Marina didn't look up from her phone. "Perfect for ghost hunting."

Thunder rumbled in the distance, seconding the motion, and Nancy pulled Derek out the door.



The coastal road ran gray and slick beneath a sky still deciding. In the Tesla, Nancy worked her tablet like a war room.

"If we liquidate most of my tech stocks and use the gallery as collateral..."

Derek's eyes kept drifting to the rearview mirror, where a sleek black Range Rover held station behind them like a thought he couldn't shake.

"Did that woman say something about ghost hunting?"

"Derek, focus. We need to figure out a solid offer before—"

Thunder CRASHED, close enough to feel through the seats.



Linda was already on the front steps of Ravencrest when they arrived, checking her watch, her Mercedes parked at an odd angle in the circular drive—the parking job of a woman who had arrived in a hurry and left her composure somewhere on the coast road.

The Tesla crunched up the gravel drive.

So did a Range Rover, arriving at precisely the same moment.

"No, no, no," Linda muttered.

Derek and Nancy emerged from their car just as Chad and Marina exited theirs, and the four of them stood there in the gray morning light, the mansion looming over all of them like a judge entering the courtroom.

"Marina, baby, it's even better in daylight!" Chad swept his gaze across the Gothic facade with a producer's appetite. "Major 'Crimson Peak' energy."

Marina removed her designer sunglasses with practiced grace. "The TikTok possibilities are literally endless."

"Mr. Wellington, Ms. St. Clair..." Linda's smile was a structural failure in progress. "You're early."

Nancy turned to Derek as the realization landed. "Wait. *You're* the LA buyers?"

Thunder crashed—no lightning, no warning, just the sky clearing its throat. And above them, the mansion's dark windows seemed to darken further, like pupils dilating.



Inside, the foyer received them all with its chandelier and its ravens and its portrait of Dr. Blackwood, whose painted eyes had a full house to follow now. Their footsteps echoed on the ancient hardwood.

Nancy noticed it immediately: the large area rug had moved. Yesterday it had sat askew, one corner curled to reveal that trace of old red paint worked into the floorboards. Today it lay perfectly squared and perfectly flat, covering the spot entirely—smoothed out overnight in a house that had, officially, been empty. She caught Derek's eye and dropped her gaze meaningfully to the rug. He looked. He understood. Neither said a word.

"Exclusive private club," Chad was saying, framing the staircase with his hands. "Very 'American Horror Story' meets Soho House."

"Actually," Derek said, and there was an edge of rasp in his voice that hadn't been there yesterday, "we've already made an offer."

Marina's laugh rang artificial against the mansion's silence. "Oh, honey, that's adorable." She turned to Chad. "Show them the number."

Chad produced a check with a flourish that suggested he practiced producing checks with flourishes. Linda's eyes went wide as she read it.

Somewhere deep in the house, the pipe organ emitted a single, resonant note.

"Derek." Nancy's voice was low. "We can't compete with—"

"OH! OH! OHHHHH!"

It came out of Derek sudden and perfect and at full volume—Sam's scream, three rising notes, detonating in the foyer like a starting pistol. Everyone froze. Derek looked as surprised as any of them, a man who had just discovered his own trapdoor.

Marina recovered first, and her expression was—of all things—delighted. "Was that... a Sam Kinison impression?"

Thunder BOOMED. The crystal chandelier tinkled ominously overhead. The lights flickered.

"Perfect!" Chad snapped his fingers. "We'll turn the asylum wing into a comedy club museum. Very meta."

And the lights went out.

Darkness swallowed the foyer whole. Then lightning flashed through the tall windows, one blinding frame—and in it, in the corner of the room, stood a figure. Stocky. Long hair. Adjusting a beret with both hands, unhurried, like a performer checking his look in the wings.

The light died. The corner was empty.

"Perhaps we should reschedule," Linda said, backing toward the door.

"No!" Marina's eyes were shining. "This is exactly what we need." She grabbed Chad's arm. "Are you thinking what I'm thinking?"

"Overnight auction," Chad said. "Whoever lasts till morning gets the property."

"That's insane," Nancy said. "The mansion isn't ready—I mean, *safe*. To stay here. With the mansion in this kind of shape..."

Lightning flashed again. And in the ornate mirror on the foyer wall, Derek's reflection stood among the others—wearing Sam's beret, though his actual head remained bare.

"We'll take that bet."

It was Derek's mouth that said it, but it was Sam's voice—perfect, chilling, and absolutely certain.

Linda was already retreating toward the study, heels clicking rapidly on the hardwood. "I really can't allow—"

THUNDER CRASHED, and the massive front door slammed shut by itself, the sound echoing through the foyer like a gunshot.

"Did everyone see that?" Marina spun in a circle, thrilled. "Tell me someone was filming!"

"I'm sure it was just the wind," Linda said, in the voice of a woman who had never once believed it was the wind. She pulled her phone from her pocket. "I... need to make a call."



In the study, behind a door not quite closed, Linda paced before floor-to-ceiling bookshelves, phone pressed to her ear, storm clouds stacking themselves over the Pacific outside the window.

"They're both here. Both want it..." She listened. "Yes, I know we didn't plan... But maybe this is—" A pause. "Are you sure? The energy tonight will be—" A longer pause, and whatever came through the phone in that pause took the argument out of her entirely. "I understand. Yes. I'll set it up."

She lowered the phone and stood a moment, watching the storm darken over the water, with the expression of a woman who had just been reminded which side of the FOR SALE sign she actually worked for.



When Linda returned to the foyer, her demeanor had shifted from anxious to resigned, the chandelier casting strange shadows across her face like stage lighting she hadn't requested.

"The owner... has agreed to your proposal." She looked from Chad and Marina to Derek and Nancy, delivering the terms like a judge reading a sentence. "You'll have until sunset to prepare. After that, no one leaves until dawn. If you do leave, you will forfeit your offer—and lose any hope of buying this place!"

Somewhere in the depths of the house, the pipe organ began to play. It took the room a few bars to place the tune, and when they did, nobody said it out loud: "Another One Bites the Dust," rolling through the empty corridors with what could only be described as relish.

Derek cocked his head and produced a flawless Burt Ward: "Holy House on Haunted Hill, Batman!"

"May the best buyers win." Chad's smile was a sponsorship deal under duress. "I'll grab our equipment bags, babe."

And then, threading underneath the organ, a LAUGH rolled through the mansion's bones—three rising notes that only Derek seemed to hear, his head tilting toward it like a compass finding north.

Nancy pulled him aside, into the shadow of Dr. Blackwood's portrait, and dropped her voice. "What are we going to do?"

"Find out who this place really belongs to," Derek said—in his own voice, the calmest and surest it had sounded in fifteen years.

Nancy held his eyes a moment longer. "One night," she said. "And if a single wall bleeds, we're leaving."

Then she glanced down, and stiffened. The area rug—squared and smoothed so carefully overnight—was changing. The dark red paint beneath was soaking upward through the weave like a photograph developing, and she could now make out the faint outline of the entire symbol, the whole precise geometry of it, bleeding through the carpet. She did the eye thing. Derek looked

down. Neither of them said a word.

Above them, the chandelier crystals tinkled softly, though there was no breeze.

You never know when life's gonna hit you with the punchline.

Sometimes the punchline is a mansion.

Sometimes the punchline is you.

END OF BOOK ONE



And now—as a pipe organ somewhere wheezes into the theme from "The Ghost and Mr. Chicken," and a single light burns in Ravencrest's widow's walk—the questions you're not supposed to sleep on, delivered in your best

Vincent Price:

WILL Derek and Nancy win the bet?

WILL Chad and Marina outlast the evening's mysteries?

WILL Sam take action?

IS Linda also trapped at the mansion?

Find out in Book 2. Same ghostly channel. Same crazy story...

OH... OH... OHHHHHHHHHHH!

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Derek Devon is the pen name of a first-time novelist who spent a long career in the corporate world before deciding the stories rattling around his head deserved better than PowerPoint. He is the author of the seventeen-book science fiction series *The Last Axiom* and the debut novel *A Letter Guide for Rebecca*.

Living With the Ghost of Sam is his love letter to the golden age of stand-up comedy, to old houses with opinions, and to everyone who ever lost someone and kept the conversation going.

He lives in Florida, where the thunder is frequent and, he insists, occasionally well-timed.

ALSO BY DEREK DEVON

The Last Axiom (Books 1–15)

A Letter Guide for Rebecca